

HYDERABAD | Quota Conundrum

For the third time in six years, the Andhra Pradesh High Court has quashed the 4 per cent employment and education quota for Muslims. The court said the reservation was "religion-specific and potentially encourages religious conversions". It has left Assaduddin Owasi, Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen president and MP, unhappy. He says Muslims in Kerala and Karnataka had quotas along with those in Tamil Nadu "as a sub-backward caste". On the same day the high court gave its verdict, West Bengal announced a 10 per cent quota for Muslims in government jobs. The state BJP says "there should not be any reservation on the basis of religion". The TDP claims the Congress promised the quota only as a poll ploy. "The court



MUSLIMS PROTEST THE VERDICT AGAINST QUOTAS FOR THEM

had not found fault with reservation; its verdict was against how the policy was framed," TDP leader R. Chandrasekhar Reddy said. Chief Minister K. Rosaiah though wants to prove that the quota is no election stunt. "We'll secure legal sanctity for reservations for disadvantaged Muslims," he says. The state will now challenge the judgement in the Supreme Court.

by Amarnath K. Menon



BJP President Nitin Gadkari has gifted all officials and staffers at the party office desktop placards that say, "I like people who can get things done!" It's difficult to say whether the placards will spur the party to perform.

LUCKNOW | The Memory Hole



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI/www.indiatodayimages.com

After initiating a project to declare the Terai region of Pilibhit a tiger reserve two years ago, the Mayawati Government seems to have forgotten about the big cats. The National Tiger

Conservation Authority (NTCA), which is working to save the dwindling tiger population, had cleared the project. The Forest Department had sent the blue-prints of the proposed reserve to the Government 10 months ago. "We have sent many reminders to the state Government but to no avail," says S.P. Yadav, joint director, NTCA. India has 39 tiger reserves and national parks with a population of just 1,411 tigers. Maharashtra has been the only state to act on proposals sent by the NTCA for creating a tiger reserve; Orissa, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh have been turning a blind eye to proposals for new reserves for the endangered cats.

by Subhash Mishra

MUMBAI | English Way

Though Hindi takes a bashing every time the language issue arises, Maharashtra seems to have no issues with the Queen's language. In a move to accommodate the tribal children of the state into the mainstream, the Maharashtra Government will start dedicated English medium schools in 15 tribal districts across the state. Around 66 English medium schools have been proposed in talukas of the state primarily inhabited by tribals. Once underway, the project will benefit over 20,000 such students every year. In the initial phase, the Centre has granted Rs 12 crore each for constructing three schools and Rs 1.5 crore for administration and maintenance.

"Simultaneous programmes like scholarships to encourage enrolment and sustain attendance will also aid in improving the education scenario. This will help the children in tribal areas to avail equal opportunities in future," said, P.S. Meena, principal secretary for Tribal Affairs. The Marathi mancoos may dislike Hindi and those speaking it, but English seems to go down well with them. Both officially and politically.

by Harsha Bhat